INTRODUCTION

This book is based primarily on thousands of interviews and conversations conducted over three years with people from Acre to Be'er Sheva. Unless otherwise specified, all quotes and anecdotes are from my own reporting. Some of it is based on articles I wrote for other publications during that time. It also relies on a vast range of Hebrew, Arabic and English secondary sources, which are listed at the end of the book.

I have chosen to use the most commonly accepted transliterations of Hebrew and Arabic names, except in the cases of well-known public figures who use alternative spellings. Hence the opposition leader is Isaac Herzog, not Yitzhak. I also use the common English renderings of place names, which tend to be the Hebrew ones: Negev instead of Naqab, Hebron instead of Al-Khalil (but also Nablus instead of Shekhem). This is not a political statement, merely an attempt to make the book more accessible. In a country where even highway signs become heated political disputes, you can't please everyone.

Similarly, I adopt some Israeli euphemisms, like the phrase "illegal outpost" in reference to West Bank settlements that were built without government approval. This is not an endorsement of the Israeli position that the other settlements are legitimate, only an effort to improve readability. "Arab Israelis" and "Palestinian citizens of Israel" are used interchangeably —both to improve the prose and to reflect the community's own internal disagreements over identity.

Finally, a word about myself. I am a correspondent for *The Economist* and for *The Times* of London, and my longer-form work has been published in a number of other newspapers and magazines. I have lived in Israel for the past three-plus years, and I have made reporting trips here throughout the past decade, criss-crossing the country to cover two Gaza wars, two "third intifadas", an election campaign, and countless other stories, interviewing everyone from religious settlers to cannabis entrepreneurs (who occasionally have proved to be one and the same). I've also spent